Profile-Driven Device Placement for a RAG Pipeline

CSE 291A Option 2 — Phase 1: Measurement and Profiling

Vincent Chen, [teammate]

November 2, 2026

Abstract

We profile a three-stage retrieval-augmented QA pipeline (embedding, reranking, LLM generation) on the CPU, integrated GPU (iGPU) and NPU of an ASUS NUC 16 Pro (Intel Core Ultra 7 356H) with OpenVINO 2026.4.1. All three stages run on all three devices with no silent fallback, which we verify both from the runtime (`EXECUTION_DEVICES`) and from kernel-level activity counters. With one request at a time, the iGPU is the fastest device for every stage, and the choice of the LLM device dominates end-to-end latency (437 ms all-iGPU vs. 815 ms with the LLM on the NPU and 1.9 s on the CPU). The NPU becomes useful only when stages overlap: moving the reranker to the NPU raises throughput from 2.38 to 2.50 q/s and lowers tail latency near saturation, at a small quality cost (recall@3 0.87→0.83), because the NPU produces slightly different reranker scores. Overlapped stages slow each other through shared DRAM, not through the Python GIL. NPU behaviour is shaped by static shapes: compile time grows to minutes for large shapes, and the LLM's first-token latency depends on the compiled maximum prompt length rather than on the actual prompt.

1 Setup

Pipeline. *Query → S1 embed → vector search → S2 rerank → S3 generate.* S1 is bge-small-en-v1.5 (FP16, static shape $[b, 64]$), S2 is bge-reranker-base (FP16, $[k, 256]$, one call scores all k candidates), and S3 is Qwen2.5-1.5B-Instruct, INT4 symmetric channel-wise weights, run with the OpenVINO GenAI `LLMPipeline`. The same IRs and shapes are used on every device, so model and precision are matched. Search is exact cosine search over 25,880 passages (numpy, CPU, ≈4 ms). The prompt contains the top-3 reranked passages; S3 generates up to 32 tokens (greedy).

Data. The corpus contains real Wikipedia paragraphs: every SQuAD v1.1 paragraph plus the distractor paragraphs of 500 sampled HotpotQA questions, so every gold passage is in the corpus. Development questions: 500 sampled SQuAD v1.1 dev questions (end-to-end runs use the first 100). HotpotQA (500) is held out for Phase 2. The LLM stage sweeps use *length-controlled* prompts made of corpus text cut to exactly 256/1k/4k tokens plus a summarization instruction, with a different text per repetition, and fixed output length (`ignore_eos`). Real RAG prompts are 213–1,888 tokens (median 555 at top-3).

Machine. 16 cores (no SMT, AVX2/AVX-VNNI, no AVX-512/AMX), Intel Arc iGPU (`xe` driver), Intel NPU (`intel_vpu`, driver 1.33), 96 GB DDR5 *shared by all three devices*, Linux 7.0. The machine is shared with other projects; we record the load average with every row (1.5–7 during our runs).

2 Methodology

Our harness (`scripts/harness.py`) has four modes. (1) **Stage sweeps** measure one stage in isolation, one factor at a time: S1 batch (1/8/32 queries), S2 candidate count (10/20/50/100, real candidates retrieved for real questions), S3 prompt length (256/1k/4k) and output length (32/128/256). Each configuration has a separate model load, one recorded first run ("cold run"), and 3–10 warm repetitions; we report warm medians. (2) **End-to-end** runs process 100 dev questions under a fixed stage-to-device mapping, either sequentially or with overlap (a front worker runs S1+search+S2 for query i+1 while a back worker runs S3 for query i), and record per-stage times, EM/F1 and retrieval recall. Runs are repeated in interleaved rounds. (3) **Load** runs drive the same two-worker pipeline with closed-loop clients (1/2/4) or open-loop Poisson arrivals (0.5–3 q/s); response time is measured from arrival to

completion. (4) **Contention** runs measure S3 decode while an S2 aggressor loops on another device, either in a thread of the same process or in a separate process.

Instrumentation (all without root):

- *Placement*: `EXECUTION_DEVICES` for S1/S2; for all stages, per-process DRM fdinfo (`drm-cycles-ccs`, iGPU compute-engine cycles) and the global NPU busy counter (`npu_busy_time_us`), sampled around each measured call.
- *Memory*: a 20 ms sampler records peaks of process RSS, system-used memory, iGPU GTT memory (`drm-resident-gtt`) and NPU memory (`drm-total-memory`); model footprint = load peak − baseline.
- *Transfer*: S1/S2 calls are split into tokenize / set input / infer / get output, and infer is repeated with zero-copy device-context input tensors; the difference estimates the plugin input copy. For S3 we use GenAI's tokenize/inference/detokenize durations. End-to-end runs log the bytes handed between stages.
- *Cold start*: `NPU_BYPASS_UMD_CACHING=YES` bypasses the NPU driver's compile cache and `NEO_CACHE_PERSISTENT=0` disables the iGPU kernel cache; 3 repetitions.

Energy was not measured. RAPL counters are root-only on this machine and we have no other reliable instrumentation, so we make no energy claims at any level (accelerator, package or machine).

3 Support matrix and actual placement

Table 1: Support matrix. Load = model load + compile time with a warm compile cache / true cold. "Busy" is the median share of the call's latency during which the NPU busy counter advanced; iGPU cycles were zero on every non-iGPU run and NPU busy was zero on every non-NPU run.

Stage	Device	Runs	Fallback	Activity evidence	Load warm / cold (s)
S1 embed	CPU	yes	none	no iGPU/NPU activity	0.39 / 0.39
	iGPU	yes	none	8.8×10^4 cycles/call	0.44 / 1.0
	NPU	yes	none	NPU busy 92%	0.07 / 1.0
S2 rerank	CPU	yes	none	no iGPU/NPU activity	3.3 / 3.3
	iGPU	yes	none	3.6×10^6 cycles/call	3.1 / 3.8
	NPU	yes[a]	none	NPU busy 91%	0.12 / 68
S3 LLM	CPU	yes	none[b]	no iGPU/NPU activity	0.67 / 0.67
	iGPU	yes	none[b]	3.7×10^7 cycles/call	1.6 / 3.0
	NPU	yes[c]	none[b]	NPU busy 95%	4.9 / 10.8

[a] Static shapes only; 50 candidates take 241 s to compile, 100 candidates 21 min and then run at 14.2 s per call (iGPU: 0.52 s). Scores differ slightly from CPU/iGPU (Sec. 7). [b] `LLMPipeline` does not report `EXECUTION_DEVICES`; placement is established from activity counters only. [c] Requires symmetric INT4 weights: the asymmetric INT8 export compiles on the NPU but generates garbage. The NPU LLM must share no process with another NPU model since 2026-11 (Sec. 8). Load shown for a 1,152-token maximum prompt.

All nine stage–device pairs run, and the activity counters agree with the requested device in every case (Table 1): there is no silent CPU fallback, including for the LLM, where the runtime itself does not report placement. The NPU, however, is the least flexible device. It requires static input shapes, including a maximum prompt length for the LLM, which is fixed at compile time. Compile cost grows quickly with shape size. The OpenVINO NPU compile cache hides this after the first load: the reranker's load time is 0.12 s with a warm cache but 68 s cold. The iGPU also compiles kernels, but cold loads cost only 0.5–1.4 s more.

4 Per-stage profiles

S1 (embedding) is negligible in the pipeline: 1.4–7.8 ms per query at batch 1. The iGPU is fastest at every batch size and the CPU scales worst (202 ms at batch 32). At batch 1 all three devices are dominated by fixed overhead: 54–65% of the 64-token input is padding, yet shortening it barely changes latency.

S2 (rerank) is the most expensive retrieval stage and is linear in candidate count on CPU and iGPU. The iGPU is fastest at every size (71–522 ms). The NPU is 1.2–1.6× slower up to 50 candidates and then breaks down at 100 (14.2 s, 27× the iGPU). The CPU is 15–20× slower than the iGPU. S2 cost is also linear in sequence length (20 candidates at seq. 128/192/256: iGPU 48/73/99 ms), and 30% of the computed tokens are padding while 12.6% of real candidate pairs are truncated at 256 tokens.

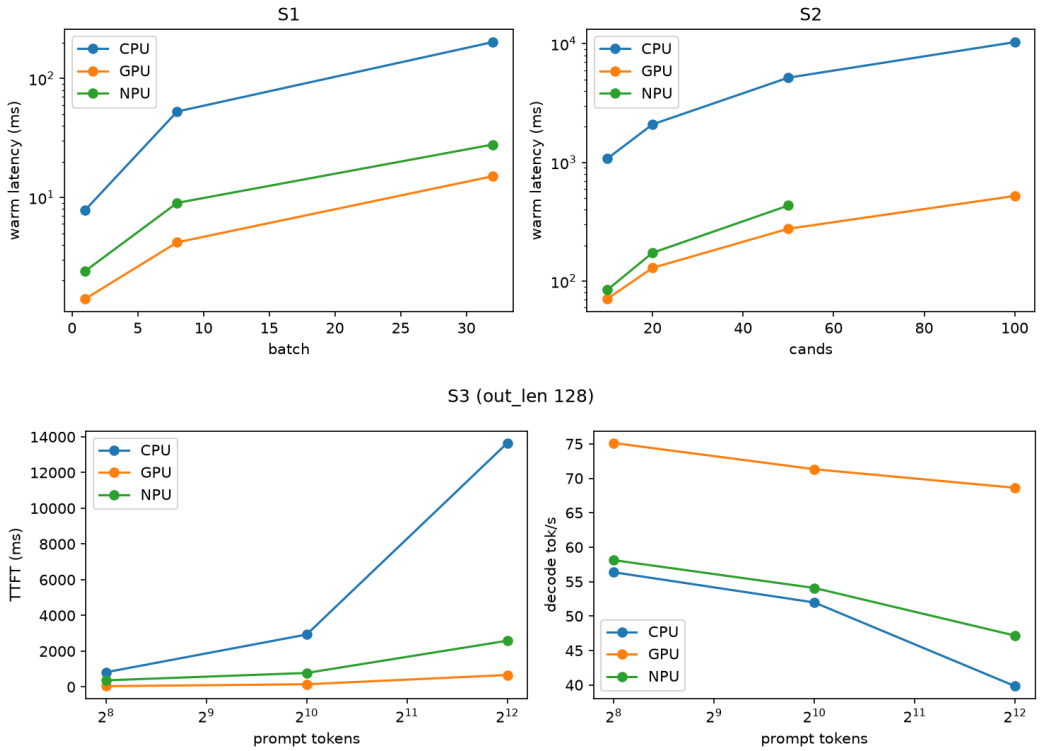


Figure 1: Warm per-stage latency ("GPU" = iGPU). Top: S1 vs. batch size (queries), S2 vs. candidate count (log scale; NPU at 100 candidates, 14.2 s, omitted). Bottom: S3 time to first token (TTFT) and decode rate vs. prompt length, output 128 tokens; the NPU points use one pipeline compiled for a 4,224-token maximum prompt.

S3 (generation). The iGPU is fastest in both phases: its prefill is about 20× faster than the CPU's and 2.5–4× faster than the NPU's and its decode runs at 69–75 tok/s. Decode is memory-bandwidth bound, so the gap is smaller there: the NPU (47–58 tok/s) and CPU (40–56 tok/s) are close at short prompts, while the CPU slows most with context. Output length only scales total time (TPOT is constant across 32/128/256 tokens on the iGPU). The NPU's TTFT depends on the compiled maximum prompt length, not on the actual prompt: a 256-token prompt takes 100 ms with a 384-token pipeline but 366 ms with a 4,224-token pipeline, because the NPU prefills the full static shape.

5 Initialization, memory and data movement

Initialization. Table 1 separates warm-cache and true cold loads. The first inference after loading costs an extra 8–12 ms on the iGPU (S1) and up to 2× the warm latency on the NPU (S2: 199 vs. 84 ms at 10 candidates). The NPU's cold costs grow with shape: the NPU LLM takes 2.0/4.9/6.2 s to load (warm cache) for maximum prompts of 384/1,152/4,224 tokens.

Memory (model footprint = load peak minus baseline). S1: 32–130 MB of iGPU memory or 67–91 MB of NPU memory. S2: 0.6–1.3 GB on the iGPU (grows with candidates; 2.0 GB peak at 100) and 0.63/0.73/0.98 GB on the NPU at 10/20/50 candidates; an uncached NPU compile additionally needs 1.7–3.2 GB of host RAM. S3: 1.0 GB on the iGPU, 1.35/1.89/2.03 GB on the NPU for maximum prompts of 384/1,152/4,224. An entire end-to-end process uses 1.7–2.4 GB of RSS. Memory is not a constraint for this pipeline on a 96 GB machine, but the NPU LLM's footprint grows with its static prompt shape.

Data movement. The three devices share DRAM, so "transfer" is a host-side copy, not a bus crossing. The payload between stages is small (per query: 1.5 KB query vector, 14.6 KB of candidate text, 2.4 KB prompt). The iGPU plugin's input copy costs 3–13 ms per S2 call (≤10% of S2); on the NPU and for S1 it is below 0.4 ms. Host-side tokenization is the larger cost: 8–35 ms per S2 call (10–15% of iGPU S2), while S3 tokenization and detokenization take under 2 ms.

Table 2: Warm medians (ms). S3: TTFT / time per output token (TPOT). NPU S3 TTFT is given for a pipeline compiled for the prompt length (max. prompt 384/1152/4224) and, in parentheses, for one compiled for 4,224 tokens.

S1 batch	CPU	iGPU	NPU	S2 cands	CPU	iGPU	NPU
1	7.8	1.4	2.4	10	1,076	71	84
8	52.8	4.2	9.0	20	2,092	129	173
32	202	15.1	27.9	50	5,180	276	434
				100	10,319	522	14,200
S3 prompt	TTFT: CPU / iGPU / NPU				TPOT: CPU / iGPU / NPU		
256	819	39	100 (366)		17.7	13.3	17.4
1k	2,932	146	771 (779)		19.2	14.0	18.6
4k	13,652	665	2,583		25.1	14.6	21.2

Table 3: End-to-end, 100 SQuAD dev questions, top-3 passages, warm. Sequential = one query at a time; overlap = S1+S2 of query i+1 run during S3 of query i. Rows with overlap numbers: 3 rounds, std of q/s ≤ 0.01; others: 1 round. Representative mappings of all 27 measured; mappings that differ only in S1 are within 3%.

Mapping (S1/S2/S3)	median ms	p90 ms	S2 ms	S3 ms	q/s seq.	q/s overlap	recall@3 / F1
iGPU/iGPU/iGPU	437	621	118	316	2.23	2.38	0.87 / 0.36
NPU/NPU/iGPU	559	755	231	321	1.74	**2.50**	0.83 / 0.34
NPU/iGPU/iGPU	437	627	117	317	2.21	2.38	0.87 / 0.36
NPU/NPU/NPU	816	1,089	169	642	1.21	–	0.83 / 0.33
iGPU/iGPU/NPU	842	1,095	121	709	1.20	–	0.87 / 0.38
iGPU/iGPU/CPU	1,866	2,445	126	1,731	0.52	–	0.87 / 0.34
NPU/CPU/iGPU	2,435	2,621	2,092	332	0.41	0.47	0.87 / 0.36
CPU/CPU/CPU	3,860	4,392	2,097	1,729	0.26	–	0.87 / 0.34

6 End-to-end results

All 27 mappings were measured sequentially (Table 3 lists representatives). Latency is set by the S3 device first and the S2 device second: S3 on the iGPU gives 437–573 ms, on the NPU 815–845 ms and on the CPU 1.9–2.0 s, and S2 on the CPU adds about 2 s. S1 placement does not matter (within 3%). For a single user issuing one query at a time, **the best single device (all-iGPU) is also the best mapping**: no heterogeneous mapping beats it.

Overlap. When query i+1's retrieval overlaps query i's generation, all-iGPU gains only 7% (2.23→2.38 q/s) because both stages compete for the same device. Putting S2 on the NPU lets the stages run on different devices: throughput rises 44% over its own sequential run (1.74→2.50 q/s) and is the highest of all mappings, 5% above all-iGPU overlap. S3 on the iGPU slows from 316 to ≈385 ms in that configuration (Sec. 7).

Load. Under Poisson arrivals (Fig. 2), all-iGPU and S2-on-NPU both saturate at ≈2.4 q/s, while S3 on the NPU saturates at 1.4 q/s (1.2 q/s if S2 is also on the NPU). Below saturation all-iGPU has lower latency (p50 at 1 q/s: 606 vs. 732 ms); near and past saturation S2-on-NPU has lower latency (p50 at 2.5 q/s: 2.9 vs. 3.2 s; at 3 q/s: 9.9 vs. 11.7 s), consistent with an independent 2-round run (p50 at 2.3 q/s: 1.71 vs. 1.86 s). The best mapping therefore *changes with load*, which is the main input for the Phase 2 placement policy. Above capacity, queues grow for the whole run, so those latencies depend on the run length.

More context. Giving S3 more passages raises recall but lowers answer quality for this 1.5B model (all-iGPU, top-1/3/8: recall 0.74/0.87/0.90, F1 0.40/0.36/0.25) and increases S3 time (330 vs. 644 ms at top-1 vs. top-8).

7 Causes of device differences

Shared-memory contention, not the GIL. To explain why S3 slows when it overlaps S2, we measured iGPU decode (1k prompt, 3 rounds) under different aggressors:

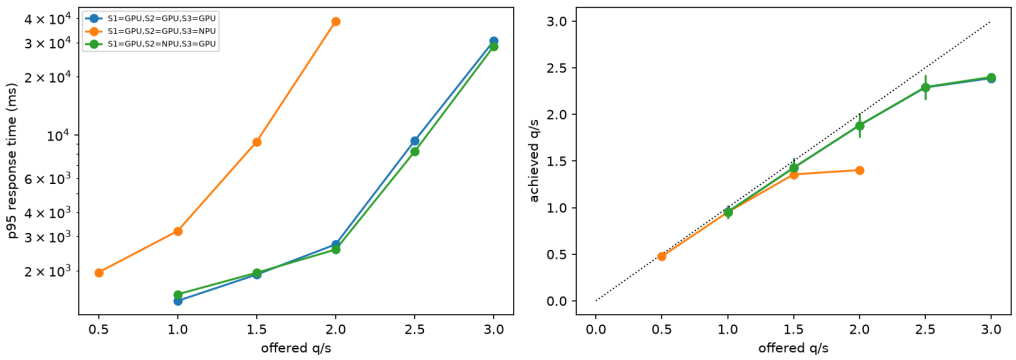


Figure 2: Open-loop Poisson load, 3 rounds of 150–300 queries per point. Left: p95 response time (log scale); right: achieved vs. offered rate. All mappings use S1 on the iGPU ("GPU").

S3 device	Aggressor	TPOT (ms)
iGPU	none	14.0
iGPU	S2 on NPU, same process (thread)	22.1
iGPU	S2 on NPU, separate process	22.1
iGPU	tokenization only, thread (holds the GIL, no accelerator work)	14.2
iGPU	S2 on CPU, separate process	15.2
NPU	none / S2 on iGPU, separate process	18.6 / 31.5

A thread and a process cause the same slowdown, and a GIL-only aggressor causes none, so the slowdown is not caused by Python. It is largest when the iGPU and NPU run at the same time (+58% and +70% TPOT) and the aggressor slows too (NPU rerank: 4.4 vs. 5.8 calls/s alone). Both accelerators stream weights and activations from the same DRAM, and decode is bandwidth bound. This bounds the benefit of overlap and must be part of a placement model.

Static shapes on the NPU explain its LLM TTFT (prefill of the full compiled length), its compile times and its breakdown at 100 candidates. **Padding** costs all devices equally: 30% of S2 tokens are padding. **Prefix caching** in GenAI makes repeated prompts look nearly free on CPU/iGPU (4k-token CPU TTFT 11 s cold, 77 ms on repeat) but not on the NPU; our first S3 sweep was invalid for this reason and was re-run with fresh prompts.

Output quality. S1 and S3 placement do not change retrieval, and S2 on CPU and iGPU give identical rankings. S2 on the NPU gives slightly different scores and changes the top-3 order: recall@3 drops from 0.87 to 0.82–0.83 and F1 by 0.01–0.06. S3 on the CPU or NPU gives F1 0.32–0.38 vs. 0.36 on the iGPU (different kernels, same INT4 weights; 100 questions). Placement is therefore not quality-neutral and quality must be reported next to latency.

8 Negative results and limitations

- For sequential single-user queries, **no heterogeneous mapping beats all-iGPU**; the NPU is never the fastest device for an individual stage. Its benefit appears only with overlapped requests.
- The NPU reranker is unusable at 100 candidates (21-min compile, 14.2 s per call).
- **Two NPU models in one process now fail**: since 2026-11, loading the NPU LLM together with another NPU model in the same process invalidates the first model (Level Zero null-handle error at first inference), although the same all-NPU configuration ran on 2026-10-27 and the software versions are unchanged. We run S3 in a separate process for those mappings; the extra IPC is 0.45 ms per query, and an iGPU/iGPU/NPU control gives 842 vs. 845 ms in-process. The all-NPU result is 816 ms in both setups.
- Energy was not measured (no reliable non-root instrumentation).
- The machine is shared: the load average was 1.5–7 during runs. Round-to-round throughput std is $\leq$0.01 q/s, but absolute CPU numbers may be slightly pessimistic.
- The LLM stage sweeps use length-controlled prompts; real RAG prompts are 213–1,888 tokens.

9 Device preference and Phase 2 inputs

Table 4: Which device under which condition (Phase 1 conclusion).

Stage	Preferred device	Conditions / exceptions
S1 embed	iGPU, but any device works	$<$10 ms per query on every device; avoid CPU for batches ($\geq$8).
S2 rerank	iGPU alone; NPU when overlapping S3	NPU only $\leq$50 candidates with a precompiled shape, and it costs $\approx$4 points of recall@3; never CPU.
S3 LLM	iGPU	NPU $\approx$1.9$\times$ slower e2e, with TTFT tied to its compiled max prompt; CPU only as a fallback.
Pipeline	all-iGPU at low load; S2 on NPU at high load	Crossover near 2–2.5 q/s; GPU+NPU overlap costs up to +58% S3 TPOT.

For Phase 2, the profiles above give the inputs for a lookup-table placement policy: per-stage latency as a function of candidate count and prompt length, model load and compile cost (including NPU static shapes), memory footprint, and a contention penalty for stages that overlap on the iGPU and NPU. We will evaluate it against fixed mappings and the best static configuration on held-out HotpotQA, mixed prompt lengths and varying load.

Artifacts. Code: `scripts/` (`harness.py`, `rag_common.py`, `run_phase1*.sh`, `analyze_phase1*.py`). Each run folder in `runs/` holds raw JSONL results, a code snapshot, the git revision, `pip freeze`, the environment at start and end, and its analysis: `2026-10-27_155708` (Phase 1 sweeps and 9 mappings with overlap), `2026-10-27_182944` (S3 with fresh prompts), `2026-10-28_212940` (memory, placement, transfer, cold start, concurrency, contention), `2026-11-01_170003` (all remaining mappings, prompt size, load sweep), `2026-11-02_080003` (NPU mappings with S3 in its own process).